

Islands

TREASURES OF NATURE

Amidst the vast sea and above the waves, under the sun, islands emerge as hidden treasures that transport you to untouched beauty, waiting to be explored. With a vast coastline, Gujarat is undoubtedly blessed with many beautiful and mesmerizing islands too. To unlock these hidden gems and further develop tourism prospects of islands, the State Government has formed the Gujarat Island Development Authority (GIDA). The initial focus of GIDA is to identify and map the islands along Gujarat's coastline and explore their development potential. Presently, Pirotan Island, Shiyal-Savai Bet and Beyt Dwarka have been distinguished as islands with a potential for the development of tourism and related activities.

Pirotan Island: Where Flora, Fauna and Adventure Await

Pirotan is a small island located in the Gulf of Kutch, in Gujarat's Jamnagar District. With an area of around 100 hectares, the island is part of the Marine National Sanctuary. It is mostly uninhabited except for the workers at the lighthouse. It is, however, an ideal location for enjoying moments of solitude. If you are lucky, you may even spot aquatic life such as jellyfish here.

The island is known for its rich biodiversity and is home to a variety of plant and animal species, including mangroves, coral reefs, and a wide range of fish and bird species. Neem, kathi, amla, babul, cher and other trees can be seen. Beautiful beaches and scenic views make it an ideal spot to spend some memorable time here. This destination stands out as a unique place offering unparalleled opportunities to visitors for nature-based education and experiential learning.

Beyt Dwarka: Bridging the Glorious Past and the Modern Present

Beyt Dwarka's rich historical significance makes it an intriguing and captivating tourist spot. As per Hindu mythology, Lord Krishna's kingdom was established at Dwarka, while Beyt Dwarka's Dwarkadhish Temple is said to have been the residence of Lord Krishna during his ruling years at Dwarka. Submerged remains of the ancient Dwarka are along this coastline.

With the vision to develop Beyt Dwarka as a prominent religious tourism destination and unlock the hidden tourism potential of the place through eco-sensitive and sustainable design and strategies, the State Government has taken the initiative to prepare the Holistic Master Plan for Beyt Dwarka and identified projects to enhance the overall experience of the tourist visiting Beyt Dwarka. Currently, this island sees 18-19 lakh visitors each year.

Although now Beyt Dwarka can be accessed using ferry services from Okha, with the completion of the new 2.3-km-long Signature Bridge by the State Government over the sea connecting Okha with Beyt Dwarka, the overall connectivity to Beyt Dwarka Island will improve. The number of tourists visiting this island will improve as tourists will be able to access the island in their own vehicles.

Kori Creek: Preserving Nature's Ecological Balance

Kori Creek is located along the coastline of Gujarat and is known for its rich biodiversity, especially its mangrove forests. It is situated in the Kutch District and plays a crucial role in the ecological balance of the region. The creek area is an important habitat for various species of flora and fauna and supports local fishing communities. Efforts have been made to protect and conserve the Kori Creek ecosystem, including initiatives to maintain the mangroves and protect the area from environmental degradation. To welcome tourists, the state is planning to create a boat ride experience which will include Mangrove, Dolphin and Bird Watching.

The Government's objectives are to develop a sustainable, accessible, and attractive tourist destination with cultural, natural, and adventure experiences, while contributing positively to the local economy. Tourism infrastructure here will prioritize hygiene, safety, and an engaging visitor experience. The island's westernmost point will be established as a beacon of Kutch's traditional culture and as a location for viewing the last sunset in India. The island's unique ecological features will be showcased including its diverse flora and fauna, sea species, and captivating coral reefs. Safe and engaging water sports activities are planned and there will be enhanced infrastructure and robust road connectivity from various cities.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Gujarat captivates the adventurous spirit with its rich tapestry of cultural heritage, vibrant traditions, and diverse landscapes. From the bustling markets of Ahmedabad to the serene white desert of Kutch, the state unfolds a myriad of experiences for every traveller. The warm hospitality of the people, coupled with the delectable flavours of Gujarati cuisine, creates an unforgettable journey that seamlessly blends the ancient with the modern. Whether exploring historical marvels, participating in colourful festivals, or savouring the tranquillity of nature, Gujarat invites you to embark on a journey that transcends time and leaves indelible memories. As you bid farewell to this captivating land, you carry with you not just souvenirs, but a deep appreciation for the unique tapestry that is Gujarat—a destination that beckons travellers to explore, discover, and embrace the beauty of its soul. Come and get a whiff of "Khushboo Gujarat Ki"!